SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #5 · FAMILY TRADITIONS AND HERITAGE

"I have to live up to what my family expects of me."

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Where it often comes from

Families often have unspoken scripts about career, marriage, faith, location, and success. A child may be told, openly or not, what they will be: a doctor, a farmer, a pastor, a parent. Falling short or choosing another road can feel like betrayal and bring guilt, conflict, or silence.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?" and "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind." Jeremiah says of God, "I know the plans I have for you." Each person has gifts: "God has arranged the members of the body, every one of them, according to His design." Scripture also says to honor your father and mother. Honor is respect and care. It does not require giving up the calling and life God gives you.

> *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ"* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God" (Romans 12:2).

> "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope" (Jeremiah 29:11).

> "But in fact, God has arranged the members of the body, every one of them, according to His design" (1 Corinthians 12:18).

> "Honor your father and mother, so that your days may be long in the land that the LORD your God is giving you" (Exodus 20:12).

Common self-statements

- I owe them the life they planned for me.
- If I choose differently, I am betraying them.
- I cannot disappoint my parents.
- Their approval is worth more than my own path.
- I must meet their expectations.
- My dreams do not matter.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must fulfill others' plans.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty about my choices and concluding that they are wrong.
- Mind reading: Assuming I know how my family will react.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either obey completely or betray.

Challenging questions

- What exactly does my family expect, and where did that come from?
- Which expectations fit who God made me to be, and which do not?
- What are my gifts, and what do I sense God calling me toward?
- How could I honor my family while choosing my own path?
- What would I regret if I spent my life meeting expectations?
- Who could help me talk with my family?

Truth summary

> I can honor my family without living their plan for me. God has given me my own gifts and calling. I can speak respectfully, listen to their concerns, and follow God's leading with a clear conscience.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Will of God
- Obedience
- Parenting
- Pride
- Guidance

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I have to live up to what my family expects of me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to live up to what my family expects of me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does my family expect?
- ☐ Which fit me?
- ☐ What is God calling me toward?
- ☐ How can I honor them?
- ☐ What will I say?
- ☐ Who can help?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I seek God's approval first.
- ☐ God has plans for me.
- ☐ He arranged me according to His design.
- ☐ I can honor without obeying every expectation.
- ☐ My calling is mine to discern.
- ☐ I can speak respectfully and stand firm.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Romans 12:2**
  "Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God."
- ☐ **Jeremiah 29:11**
  "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ My path and my honor: Each week, note one choice made prayerfully and one act of honor toward family.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Galatians 1:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I seek God's approval first and honor my family with love.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Will of God" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write the expectations. List what your family expects and which you hold yourself.
- ☐ Sort them. Mark which fit you and which do not.
- ☐ Pray about your calling. Ask God what He has for you.
- ☐ Plan a respectful conversation. Prepare what you will say, with kindness.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to live up to what my family expects of me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	My path and my honor
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to live up to what my family expects of me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I want to honor my family and follow You. Show me what You have called me to, give me wisdom to speak with respect, and free me from living for others' approval. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.